

SAFER RECRUITMENT POLICY

1. Introduction

Sporting Chance Project Ltd (SCP) is committed to safeguarding and promoting the welfare of every learner and to recruiting only people who are suitable to work with children, young people and, where applicable, adults at risk. Safer recruitment is a continuing process extending from role design and advertising through selection, pre-employment checks, induction, supervision and the management of concerns.

SCP provides Alternative Learning Provision across Bristol, Bath and North East Somerset (B&NES) and South Gloucestershire, including provision for learners aged 16 and 17 and some learners aged 18 or over. A child is anyone under 18. Checks will be determined by the legal eligibility of the particular role and the activities actually undertaken, not by job title alone.

This policy takes effect on 1 September 2026. It has regard to Keeping Children Safe in Education 2026 (KCSIE), Working Together to Safeguard Children 2026, the Safeguarding Vulnerable Groups Act 2006, the Protection of Freedoms Act 2012, the Rehabilitation of Offenders Act 1974 and Exceptions Order, the Education and Training (Welfare of Children) Act 2021, the Equality Act 2010, the Immigration, Asylum and Nationality Act 2006, data-protection legislation and current Disclosure and Barring Service (DBS) guidance. Where school- or college-specific requirements do not apply directly to SCP, SCP adopts the relevant KCSIE safer-recruitment standards as good practice and to meet its commissioning responsibilities.

2. Purpose and principles

This policy is intended to:

- deter, reject or identify people who may pose a risk of harm or who are unsuitable to work with SCP learners;
- ensure recruitment decisions are fair, evidence-based, consistent and properly recorded;
- verify identity, qualifications, employment history, legal eligibility and suitability before work begins;
- promote equality of opportunity and make reasonable adjustments for disabled applicants; and
- ensure that safeguarding continues through induction, probation, supervision and workforce management.

No single check establishes suitability. SCP will assess the complete information available and resolve discrepancies or concerns before confirming an appointment.

3. Scope and responsibilities

This policy applies to employees, mentors, tutors, agency and temporary workers, contractors, self-employed people, volunteers, work-experience participants and any other person recruited or engaged to work for or on behalf of SCP. Proportionate checks also apply to visitors according to the purpose, frequency and supervision of their attendance.

Tony Ricketts, as SCP's sole active Director and DSL, has overall responsibility for ensuring that safer-recruitment arrangements are implemented and that required checks are complete. Recruitment administration may be delegated, but accountability for the appointment decision remains with SCP. Where Tony is an applicant, connected to an applicant or otherwise conflicted, SCP will appoint a suitably independent person to oversee the process and will obtain HR, commissioning-body or safeguarding advice as appropriate.

At least one member of every interview panel will have completed appropriate safer-recruitment training. Wherever practicable, shortlisting and interview decisions will involve at least two people. Panel members must declare personal or professional conflicts of interest.

4. Planning the recruitment

4.1 Role assessment and approval

Before advertising or engaging a person, SCP will approve an up-to-date job description and person specification identifying the role's duties, level of contact with learners, supervision arrangements, safeguarding responsibilities, qualifications and the checks legally available and required. SCP will determine whether the role is regulated activity with children and/or adults and record the basis for the DBS level requested.

From 1 September 2026, the previous supervision exemption for regulated activity with children is removed. A volunteer carrying out teaching, training, instructing or supervising children frequently, on more than three days in a 30-day period, or overnight is therefore in regulated activity and requires an enhanced DBS check with Children's Barred List information. SCP will reassess both new and existing volunteer roles against the revised definition and ensure the required barred-list status check is completed before regulated activity begins.

4.2 Advertising

Advertisements and recruitment information will include:

- SCP's commitment to safeguarding and promoting learner welfare;
- the safeguarding responsibilities of the role;
- the relevant qualifications, experience and competencies;
- the anticipated DBS level and barred-list check where the role is legally eligible;
- that shortlisted candidates will be subject to an online search as part of due diligence; and
- that the post is exempt from the Rehabilitation of Offenders Act 1974 where applicable, together with information on how criminal-record information must be declared.

5. Applications, shortlisting and online searches

5.1 Application information

Applicants must complete SCP's application form. A curriculum vitae will not be accepted on its own. The application must provide full identifying and contact details, relevant qualifications, a complete chronological employment and education history since leaving secondary education, explanations for gaps, referees, relationships with existing SCP personnel, and the declarations appropriate to the role.

The form will make clear that knowingly providing false or misleading information, or omitting relevant information, may lead to withdrawal of an offer, dismissal and/or referral to relevant authorities.

5.2 Shortlisting

The same selection criteria will be applied consistently to every applicant. Shortlisters will scrutinise applications for unexplained gaps, repeated changes of employment, anomalies, discrepancies, incomplete answers, safeguarding concerns and statements requiring clarification. These matters will be recorded and explored at interview. Shortlisted candidates will be asked to complete any required self-declaration of criminal history and information that may make them unsuitable to work with children, in a confidential and legally compliant form.

5.3 Online searches

SCP will consider carrying out an online search on shortlisted candidates as part of its due diligence. The search is intended only to identify publicly available information that may require exploration at interview, including information relevant to safeguarding or professional suitability. Candidates will be told that a search may take place.

Where practicable, a person who is not making the selection decision will conduct the search using a consistent, proportionate method. Only relevant findings will be recorded and shared with the panel; protected-characteristic information and irrelevant personal material will not be used. The candidate will be given an opportunity to explain relevant findings. Online information will never replace the required identity, reference, DBS or other checks.

6. Interview and selection

Applicants will normally be interviewed in person, or by secure video where justified, using a structured and recorded process. The panel will verify identity at interview where practicable and assess the applicant's suitability, motivation, values, professional boundaries, understanding of safeguarding, response to concerns, and ability to work safely with SCP's learner group. Questions will probe gaps, discrepancies and relevant online-search or self-declaration information.

Reasonable adjustments will be offered. Selection decisions will be based on the published criteria and documented. Any practical exercise involving learners will be risk assessed, appropriately supervised and will not give a candidate unsupervised access to children.

7. Conditional offer and pre-employment checks

All appointments are conditional until SCP has obtained, checked and judged satisfactory every check applicable to the role. The level of check will be based on law and current eligibility guidance. SCP will not request a barred-list or higher-level DBS check for a role that is not legally eligible.

7.1 Core checks

Before a person starts work, SCP will, as applicable:

- verify identity using current DBS identity-checking requirements and retain a compliant record;
- obtain evidence of the right to work in the UK and complete any required follow-up check;
- verify relevant professional and academic qualifications with the awarding body or other authoritative source where necessary;
- obtain an enhanced DBS certificate for eligible work with children and include Children's Barred List information where the role is regulated activity or another legal route permits it;
- check the Adults' Barred List only where the role involves regulated activity with adults and is legally eligible;
- check any applicable prohibition, restriction, sanction or professional-registration information where relevant to the role;
- complete appropriate overseas checks where the applicant has lived or worked outside the UK;
- obtain and verify satisfactory references; and
- after a conditional offer, establish whether the person has the health and physical capacity to perform the role, making reasonable adjustments where required.

A health question will not be used before an offer except where permitted by section 60 of the Equality Act 2010, such as establishing whether an applicant can participate in an assessment or whether a genuine occupational requirement can be met.

7.2 DBS certificates and barred-list information

The applicant must show SCP the original DBS certificate. SCP will check the certificate details against identity information, assess any disclosed information and record the certificate number, level, workforce, barred-list status, date and checker. SCP will not retain a certificate copy for longer than necessary and will handle DBS information in accordance with the DBS Code of Practice and data-protection law.

A barred person must not be permitted to engage in regulated activity. If a check indicates a possible barred-list match, SCP will stop the appointment or duties and verify the position through the proper DBS route. SCP will report suspected criminal or safeguarding matters to the appropriate authority.

An individual may join the DBS Update Service when a new DBS check is applied for or within 30 calendar days of the certificate's issue date. DBS Update Service status checks may be used only with the individual's consent and where the original certificate is for the same workforce and level, including the same barred-list information. SCP will inspect the original certificate before relying on a status check and will obtain a new DBS check if the role or certificate is not equivalent or the status has changed.

7.3 Starting before the DBS certificate is available

This will be exceptional. A person will not undertake regulated activity until SCP has confirmed that they are not barred through a lawful route. Before any start pending an enhanced certificate, SCP must complete all other checks, obtain the appropriate separate barred-list check where legally accessible, complete and approve a written risk assessment,

define close supervision and restricted duties, inform the commissioner where required, and set a short review date. The arrangement will end immediately if information raises a concern.

7.4 References

SCP will normally obtain two references, including the applicant's current or most recent employer and, where the applicant has worked with children, the employer most relevant to that work. References will be requested directly from an appropriate senior person using an SCP template and will not be accepted as open testimonials. Personal referees will be used only where there is no suitable employment referee and with additional verification.

References will seek factual information about employment dates, role, reason for leaving, suitability to work with children, substantiated safeguarding concerns or disciplinary action, and whether the referee would re-employ the person. SCP will verify the source, compare the reference with the application, clarify vague or contradictory information directly with the referee and record the resolution. References should be obtained before interview where practicable, subject to the applicant's consent and fair recruitment practice.

7.5 Overseas applicants and overseas history

A DBS check does not cover criminal records held overseas. For a person who has lived or worked outside the UK, SCP will make such further checks as it considers appropriate, taking account of the country, duration, role, age at the time and the availability and reliability of evidence. This may include an overseas criminal-record certificate, certificate of good conduct, professional standing or employer checks. Documents will be authenticated and translated where necessary. If evidence cannot be obtained, SCP will document a proportionate risk assessment and decide whether sufficient assurance exists to appoint; the absence of an available overseas check will not be treated as automatic clearance.

7.6 Criminal-record information and suitability decisions

SCP will comply with the Rehabilitation of Offenders Act 1974, its Exceptions Order and DBS filtering rules. Applicants will be required to disclose only information that SCP is legally entitled to request. A criminal record will not automatically prevent appointment. A documented assessment will consider relevance, seriousness, recency, pattern, circumstances, the applicant's explanation, evidence of rehabilitation, the duties and degree of access to vulnerable people. Barred-list status or another legal prohibition cannot be overridden by a risk assessment.

8. Agency staff, contractors and self-employed workers

Before an agency or third-party worker provides education or works for SCP, SCP will obtain written confirmation that the supplier has completed the same checks SCP would otherwise carry out for the role, including the correct DBS and barred-list checks, identity, right to work, qualifications and overseas checks as applicable, and that the supplier will notify SCP of relevant information. SCP will verify the person's identity on arrival and, where required or considered appropriate, inspect the original DBS certificate.

Contractors and self-employed people will be assessed according to their actual duties. Where SCP cannot request a check directly, it will require appropriate evidence through a commissioning organisation, umbrella body or other lawful route, including inspecting a certificate lawfully obtained directly by the self-employed person, and will ensure that the check is at the level required for the role. A person without the required assurance will not have unsupervised access to learners or undertake regulated activity. Contracts will require compliance with SCP's safeguarding code, immediate reporting of concerns and cooperation with allegations and DBS referral processes.

9. Volunteers, visitors and work experience

SCP will complete a written role and risk assessment for volunteers, considering the activity, frequency, supervision, setting and learner contact. From 1 September 2026, volunteers carrying out relevant activity with children at the required frequency are regulated activity even when supervised and must have an enhanced DBS check with Children's Barred List information. Occasional activity that does not meet the legal conditions will be managed through proportionate checks and effective supervision; a barred-list check will not be requested without lawful eligibility.

Visitors will be identified, signed in, given safeguarding information and supervised according to risk. Visitor status will not be used to avoid recruitment checks where a person is in reality undertaking regular work. For work-experience participants, SCP will assess age, duties, frequency and supervision and complete the checks legally available for the particular arrangement.

10. Central record and recruitment file

SCP will maintain a secure central record of recruitment and vetting checks for all relevant people. Although SCP may not be legally required to maintain a school Single Central Record in every circumstance, its central record will follow the KCSIE model where applicable and support commissioner assurance. It will record the person's role and start date; identity; right to work; qualifications; DBS level, workforce, barred-list information, certificate number and date; overseas checks; references; prohibition or professional checks where applicable; the date of each check and the person who completed it; and any approved risk assessment.

Recruitment files will contain the application, shortlisting and interview records, references, check evidence, decision and reasons, conditional offer and risk assessments. Information will be accurate, access-controlled, retained according to SCP's retention schedule and data-protection requirements, and securely destroyed when no longer required. Unsuccessful-candidate records will normally be retained for six months after the process unless there is a documented reason for longer retention.

11. Induction, probation and continuing suitability

Every new worker will receive safeguarding induction before or at the start of duties, proportionate to the role. This will include SCP's Child Protection and Safeguarding Policy, Staff Code of Conduct, allegations and low-level-concerns procedure, whistleblowing, online safety, information sharing, professional boundaries, emergency arrangements and the identity of the DSL and Deputy DSLs. Understanding will be checked and acknowledgement recorded.

Employees and regular workers will be subject to an appropriate probation or review period with documented supervision. SCP will respond to conduct, performance or safeguarding concerns promptly and will make referrals to the LADO, DBS, police, professional regulator or other body when the relevant threshold is met. Staff must immediately disclose any change that may affect their suitability, right to work, professional status or ability to undertake regulated activity. SCP may use periodic DBS Update Service checks where lawful, consented and proportionate, but continuing safeguarding culture and supervision do not depend on repeat DBS checking alone.

Employees who do not maintain an active DBS Update Service subscription may be required to undertake a new DBS check at intervals determined by the organisation's safeguarding risk assessment and policy.

12. Concerns, complaints and referrals

A safeguarding concern about an applicant or worker must be reported immediately to Tony Ricketts as DSL. If the concern is about Tony, involves a conflict of interest or cannot safely be reported to him, it must be reported directly to the relevant Local Authority Designated Officer (LADO) and, where appropriate, the commissioning body. Concerns about recruitment fairness may be raised through SCP's complaints or grievance arrangements, but safeguarding action must not be delayed.

Where SCP removes a person from regulated activity, or would or might have removed them had they not left, because the DBS referral conditions are met, SCP will make a referral to the DBS as a legal duty. Resignation or a settlement agreement will not prevent completion of safeguarding enquiries or required referrals. Professional-regulator referrals will also be made where applicable.

13. Monitoring and review

The Director will monitor compliance through periodic checks of recruitment files, the central record, training, volunteer assessments, agency assurances and outstanding or expiring evidence. Any omission will be risk assessed and corrected promptly. This policy will be reviewed at least annually and earlier following legislative or statutory-guidance changes, a safeguarding incident, audit findings or changes to SCP's provision.

14. Related SCP documents

- Child Protection and Safeguarding Policy;
- Allegations Against Staff, Low-Level Concerns and LADO Procedure;
- Staff Code of Conduct (within the Child Protection and Safeguarding Policy);
- Whistleblowing Policy;
- Data Protection and Information Sharing arrangements; and
- Equality, complaints, disciplinary and grievance procedures.

15. Key external references

- Keeping Children Safe in Education 2026, Part Three;
- Working Together to Safeguard Children 2026;
- Disclosure and Barring Service eligibility guidance and Code of Practice;
- KCSIE 2026 Part Three and Schedule 4 to the Safeguarding Vulnerable Groups Act 2006, as amended by the Crime and Policing Act 2026;
- Home Office right-to-work checks: an employer's guide; and
- Rehabilitation of Offenders Act 1974 and Exceptions Order, as amended.

Approval and document control

This policy is approved by the Director of SCP and is subject to annual review or earlier review in response to changes in legislation, statutory guidance, organisational structure or safeguarding practice.

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